

A MEDIA ICONS AFRICA INDUSTRY PLAYBOOK

FAST, LINEAR & ON-DEMAND

*Choosing — and Combining — the Right Distribution Model for
African Content*

MEDIA ICONS AFRICA

Prepared for the education of the African media, broadcast, and content-ownership industry

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FOREWORD — A PLAYBOOK, NOT A PREFERENCE

This is not an argument for FAST over linear, or linear over SVOD. It is the tool for choosing correctly, deal by deal, market by market — and for knowing when a content owner is being asked to sign the wrong model for their situation.

Every one of the twelve books in the Asiko Monetization Library assumes a FAST platform as the starting point. This playbook steps back and asks the more fundamental question: FAST versus linear satellite versus SVOD/TVOD/VOD — what actually is each one, how does each one make money, who wins and who is exposed under each, and how does an operator or a content owner in Africa decide which one (or which combination) is right for a specific piece of content, a specific market, and a specific moment in a business's life. Understanding this is not academic. It is the difference between a content owner signing a deal that builds their business and signing one that quietly strip-mines it.

CHAPTER 1 — WHY YOU NEED TO UNDERSTAND THIS BEFORE YOU SIGN ANYTHING

1.1 The cost of not knowing the difference

A content owner who cannot clearly distinguish a FAST carriage agreement from an SVOD licence from a satellite DTH deal is not in a position to negotiate any of them properly — and this industry has already paid for that ignorance once. Telecom-backed platforms that launched as ad-funded FAST-style services and then quietly drifted toward subscription broke trust with content owners specifically because nobody had been clear, up front, about which model was actually being run, what it implied for payment timing, and what would happen if the model changed mid-relationship.

1.2 Why this matters more in Africa than almost anywhere else

Mature media markets have decades of case law, standard contract templates, and institutional memory around what a FAST deal, a linear carriage deal, and an SVOD licence each typically look like. Much of the African industry is negotiating these structures for the first time, often across a language of Western streaming jargon that has not yet been translated into what it actually means for a Nigerian, Ghanaian, or Kenyan producer's cash flow. This playbook exists to close that specific gap.

THE TEST THIS PLAYBOOK WANTS YOU TO BE ABLE TO PASS

Handed any distribution contract, can you say — in one sentence — which of these three models it actually is, who is taking the financial risk, and how and when you get paid? If not, this playbook is for you.

CHAPTER 2 — THE THREE MODELS, DEFINED PRECISELY

Model	Definition	Viewer Experience	Who Bears the Financial Risk
FAST (Free Ad-Supported Streaming Television)	Linear, scheduled, always-on channels delivered over the internet, free to the viewer, funded entirely by advertising.	Feels like traditional TV — the viewer tunes in to a channel rather than choosing a title, and cannot skip or pay to remove ads.	The platform — it must sell enough advertising to cover content and infrastructure cost; the viewer risks nothing.
Linear Satellite / DTH (Direct-to-Home)	Scheduled channels delivered via satellite broadcast to a dish and set-top box, funded by a mix of subscription fees and advertising.	Traditional pay-TV — a monthly or annual subscription unlocks a bundle of channels, often tiered by package.	Shared between the platform (content and satellite capacity cost) and the viewer (who pays a recurring subscription regardless of how much they watch).
SVOD / TVOD / VOD	On-demand content the viewer chooses individually, funded by a recurring subscription (SVOD), a per-title purchase or rental (TVOD), or free/ad-supported on-demand (a VOD variant closer to AVOD).	App-based, on-demand — the viewer searches or browses a catalogue and presses play on a specific title.	The viewer (who must decide to pay before or during consumption) and the platform (which must acquire/produce a catalogue attractive enough to justify that payment).

2.1 The one distinction that matters most

FAST and linear satellite are both schedule-driven — the broadcaster decides what plays when, and the viewer’s only choice is which channel to tune to.

SVOD/TVOD/VOD is catalogue-driven — the viewer decides what to watch and when. This single difference cascades into almost everything else in this playbook: how each model is monetised, what it costs to launch, what it demands of content owners, and how forgiving or unforgiving each one is of an African market’s connectivity and payment realities.

CHAPTER 3 — HOW EACH MODEL ACTUALLY MONETISES

3.1 FAST monetisation

Advertising is the entire revenue base — pre-roll, mid-roll, and post-roll ad pods, channel and franchise sponsorship, and programmatic fill (the Asiko Monetization Library's Books 1, 4, and 6 cover this in full). The viewer pays nothing; the advertiser pays for reach and, increasingly, for measurable attention.

3.2 Linear satellite monetisation

A blended model: subscription revenue from viewers (often tiered into bundles — a basic package, a premium sports add-on, and so on) plus advertising sold into the same channels, frequently at a premium to pure FAST inventory because the audience is a known, paying, and therefore more "qualified" one. Channel owners on a platform like this are typically paid either a fixed annual carriage/licence fee by the platform operator, or a share of subscription revenue apportioned by viewership.

3.3 SVOD/TVOD/VOD monetisation

SVOD collects a recurring fee for unlimited catalogue access; TVOD charges per title, rented or purchased outright; ad-supported VOD sits closer to AVOD, monetising individual on-demand titles with inserted advertising rather than a subscription fee. In all three, content owners are typically paid either a flat licence fee for a title/catalogue, a share of subscription revenue apportioned by watch-time, or a per-transaction share for TVOD.

Model	Primary Revenue Source	How a Content Owner Is Typically Paid
FAST	Advertising	Guaranteed licence fee, and/or a share of ad revenue apportioned by viewership on their channel/content.
Linear Satellite/DTH	Subscription + advertising	Fixed carriage/licence fee, or a share of subscription revenue by viewership.
SVOD	Recurring subscription	Flat licence fee, or a share of subscription revenue apportioned by watch-time.
TVOD	Per-title transaction	A direct share of each individual purchase/rental.
Ad-supported VOD	Advertising (on-demand)	Similar to FAST — guaranteed fee and/or ad-revenue share.

CHAPTER 4 — FAST VS. LINEAR SATELLITE: THE FULL COMPARISON FOR AFRICA

Dimension	FAST OTT	Linear Satellite / DTH
Cost to launch a channel	Low to moderate — no satellite capacity lease; playout and CDN infrastructure can be usage-based and cloud-hosted.	High — satellite transponder capacity, uplink infrastructure, and set-top-box/decoder logistics are all significant fixed costs.
Cost to the viewer	Free — only requires a data connection and a device.	Requires a dish, a set-top box, and typically a recurring subscription fee.
Reach constraint	Limited by internet/data access and device penetration — a real constraint in lower-connectivity African markets, but a non-issue for the diaspora.	Limited by dish installation and geography, but not by internet connectivity — historically the more reliable reach mechanism across much of Sub-Saharan Africa.
Speed to market	Fast — a new channel can be built, tested, and launched in weeks.	Slow — satellite capacity procurement and regulatory/licensing steps typically take months.
Content flexibility	High — channels and schedules can be added, changed, or retired quickly.	Low — bouquet and channel-slot changes are constrained by contracts and satellite capacity planning cycles.
Revenue ceiling per viewer	Lower per-viewer revenue (ad-only), offset by zero access barrier and therefore larger potential reach.	Higher per-viewer revenue (subscription + ads), offset by a real access barrier (cost of the dish and subscription).
Existing African installed base	Small but rapidly growing, concentrated where data is affordable and among diaspora audiences.	Very large and deeply entrenched — decades of dish installations across the continent are a real distribution moat incumbents hold.

THE STRATEGIC READ

FAST is not trying to out-reach an entrenched satellite incumbent's installed base head-on. It is competing for the audience segment the incumbent structurally cannot serve for free — and for the diaspora audience the incumbent barely serves at all.

CHAPTER 5 — ADVANTAGES AND DISADVANTAGES FOR THE AFRICAN CONTINENT

5.1 FAST — advantages for Africa

- Zero cost to the viewer removes the single biggest adoption barrier in a price-sensitive market.
- Low launch cost lets a far wider range of local operators and content owners realistically launch their own channel, rather than only the largest, best-capitalised players.
- Naturally suited to the diaspora audience, who have reliable internet access and smart devices, and are underserved by domestic satellite platforms.

5.2 FAST — disadvantages for Africa

- Depends on data affordability and connectivity, which remain real constraints for large parts of the domestic mass-market audience.
- A purely ad-funded revenue base is more exposed to a thin or immature local ad market than a subscription-anchored model.
- No installed hardware moat — a viewer can switch to a competing free platform with zero switching cost.

5.3 Linear satellite — advantages for Africa

- A genuinely mass-market reach mechanism, unconstrained by internet infrastructure, in markets where mobile data remains expensive relative to income.
- A subscription revenue base gives more predictable, forecastable cash flow than pure ad dependency.
- Decades of consumer trust and habit around the pay-TV bundle.

5.4 Linear satellite — disadvantages for Africa

- A real cost barrier (the dish, the box, the subscription) excludes a large share of the potential audience outright.
- High fixed launch and capacity costs make it a poor fit for smaller or new content owners trying to launch their own channel independently.
- Slower to adapt content and channel lineups than an internet-native competitor.

CHAPTER 6 — ADVANTAGES AND DISADVANTAGES FOR CONTENT OWNERS

This is the chapter that matters most to the producer or channel owner deciding where to place their content — and the one most directly informed by real, first-hand African market experience already surfaced in this library.

Model	Advantages for a Content Owner	Disadvantages for a Content Owner
FAST	Low barrier to getting content distributed at all; fast to launch; can retain more direct commercial relationship (sponsorship, ad share) with the platform.	Payment is often tied to an ad-revenue share that depends entirely on the platform's own ad-sales execution — and several Nigerian FAST-style platforms have collapsed specifically because that share was promised but never paid, causing producers to pull their catalogues.
Linear Satellite/DTH	Typically a more established, contractually mature carriage relationship with a track record; a subscription-anchored platform has a steadier revenue base to pay from.	High bar to entry — a smaller or independent content owner often cannot get a satellite slot at all without an established relationship or aggregator; less flexibility to renegotiate quickly.
SVOD	Can command a real licence fee or a meaningful share of subscription revenue if the content is a genuine subscriber draw.	Payment is frequently opaque — content owners often cannot independently verify their true share of watch-time-apportioned subscription revenue.
TVOD	Direct, transparent, transaction-level payment — a content owner can see exactly what each sale generated.	Requires real, individually-marketable title-level demand; most catalogue content simply does not generate enough per-title transactions to matter.

6.1 The single most important lesson for any content owner in this chapter

A first-hand account from a content-owner contact in this library's companion books makes the underlying mechanism unusually explicit: prior Nigerian FAST-style platforms did not fail because ad-revenue share is a bad model in concept — they failed because the promised share was never actually paid out after roughly a year, at which point producers pulled their content simultaneously. The same contact's response is now the market standard content owners are moving toward: demand a guaranteed licence fee, not just a revenue-share promise, until a platform has an actual track record of paying on time — regardless of which of the three models (FAST, satellite, or SVOD) the platform is offering.

THE CONTENT OWNER'S ONE-QUESTION TEST

Before signing any distribution deal, ask: "If this platform's revenue underperforms, what happens to my payment?" A guaranteed fee answers that question; a pure revenue-share promise does not, and should be priced and negotiated accordingly.

CHAPTER 7 — FAST + LINEAR VS. SVOD/TVOD/VOD: THE REAL COMPARISON

7.1 Reframing the comparison correctly

FAST and linear satellite are both, at their core, ad-and-or-subscription-funded schedule-driven models built to reach the widest possible audience with minimal friction. SVOD, TVOD, and (ad-supported) VOD are all catalogue-driven, viewer-initiated models built to extract higher per-user value from a smaller, more committed audience. The real comparison, then, is not "which platform" but "which behaviour are you trying to fund" — mass, low-friction reach, or concentrated, higher-value engagement.

Comparison Point	FAST + Linear (Schedule-Driven)	SVOD/TVOD/VOD (Catalogue-Driven)
Access barrier for the viewer	None (FAST) to moderate (satellite subscription)	Meaningful — requires an upfront or recurring payment decision before consumption
Audience ceiling	Larger — no payment barrier limits reach (FAST) or a well-established payment habit exists (satellite)	Smaller — bounded by how many people are both willing and able to pay
Revenue per user	Lower (FAST) to moderate (satellite)	Higher, when it converts — but conversion itself is the hard part in price-sensitive markets
Content-owner payment risk	Tied to ad-sales execution (FAST) or subscriber base health (satellite)	Tied to catalogue demand and platform payment transparency
Fit for African price sensitivity	Strong — matches low willingness/ability to pay for most of the addressable audience	Weak for the mass market; workable only for a narrow, high-demand, high-income-adjacent segment

7.2 Why the collapse pattern in this market specifically favours schedule-driven models

The repeated, specific failure of prior Nigerian platforms happened when an ad-funded, schedule-driven model was abandoned in favour of a subscription pivot — breaking the free-access promise that had built the original audience and content-partner base. That history is direct evidence that, in this market at this moment, a catalogue-driven paid model is a much harder sell to both viewers and content owners than a well-executed schedule-driven one, even though catalogue-driven models can command higher revenue per user in markets where they do work.

CHAPTER 8 — BUILDING A HYBRID STRATEGY

8.1 Why "either/or" is the wrong frame

The world's most successful video businesses rarely run a single model — they run a schedule-driven ad-funded layer to build and hold the widest possible audience, and a narrow, carefully-scoped catalogue-driven paid layer on top of it for the content and audience segment that will actually pay. The FAST-first platform discussed throughout this library is not choosing FAST because paid models are wrong in principle; it is choosing FAST first, deliberately, because that is the layer that must be proven and trusted before any paid layer can be added without repeating the market's collapse pattern.

8.2 A practical sequencing rule

- **Stage 1 — Prove the schedule-driven model.** Build real audience and, critically, a real track record of paying content owners on time, funded by sponsorship and AVOD (Books 1 and 4).
- **Stage 2 — Layer in guaranteed content economics.** Use category-exclusivity sponsorship revenue to fund guaranteed licence fees, closing the content-owner trust gap directly.
- **Stage 3 — Test a narrow catalogue-driven layer.** Only once Stage 1 and 2 are proven, pilot a small TVOD offering on a handful of genuinely scarce, high-demand premium titles — never as a platform-wide subscription requirement.
- **Stage 4 — Consider satellite carriage as an extension, not a pivot.** A satellite/DTH simulcast can extend reach into audiences a pure OTT platform cannot reach, without abandoning the ad-funded core.

8.3 The trap to avoid at every stage

NEVER LET STAGE 3 OR 4 FUND STAGE 1

The collapse pattern in this market happened when platforms reached for a paid model to solve a cash problem in the ad-funded core. A hybrid strategy only works when each later stage is additive, built from a position of strength, never a rescue attempt for a stage that has not yet been made to work.

CHAPTER 9 — THE DECISION FRAMEWORK AND SCORECARD

Before committing a specific piece of content, a specific channel, or a specific market to one of these models, run it through these five questions.

Question	Points to FAST	Points to Linear Satellite	Points to SVOD/TVOD
How price-sensitive is the target audience?	Highly price-sensitive	Moderately price-sensitive, habituated to pay-TV	Low price sensitivity, willing to pay for specific content
How connectivity-constrained is the target audience?	Well-connected (diaspora, urban)	Any — satellite bypasses internet constraints	Well-connected, and comfortable with app-based viewing
How proven is the platform's payment track record with content owners?	Unproven — start here to build trust	N/A — usually an established relationship already	Should only be attempted once proven elsewhere
How scarce/individually marketable is the specific content?	Works for broad-appeal, schedule-friendly content	Works for broad-appeal, bundle-friendly content	Only works for genuinely scarce, high-demand titles
How fast does this need to launch?	Fast	Slow	Moderate

A content owner or operator whose answers point overwhelmingly toward one column has a clear signal. A mixed scorecard is itself the signal to build a hybrid strategy (Chapter 8) rather than force a single-model decision.

CHAPTER 10 — CLOSING: WHY THIS UNDERSTANDING IS THE INDUSTRY'S ACTUAL UNLOCK

This industry's deepest problem, as this whole library has argued, is a shortage of people willing to build rather than be funded. Understanding the real differences between FAST, linear satellite, and SVOD/TVOD/VOD is not a technical footnote to that problem — it is a direct piece of the fix. A producer who cannot tell these models apart cannot negotiate confidently with any distributor, cannot price their own content correctly, and cannot tell the difference between a partner building something durable and one repeating a pattern that has already collapsed once in this exact market.

THE CLOSING INSTRUCTION

Know which model you are being offered. Know who bears the financial risk in it. Know what happens to your payment if the platform underperforms. Everything else in this playbook is detail in service of being able to answer those three questions with confidence, every time.